

Three Letters from the Coast

J. L. Clements

Chapter i. The First Letter

The sea writes its letters in salt, and salt forgets nothing.

— Eleni Markou, *Coastal Notebooks* (1962)

The first letter arrived on a Tuesday, which struck Halloran as appropriate; Tuesdays were the kind of weekday on which extraordinary things were allowed to happen without anyone making a fuss about them. He had walked down to the post office at the usual hour, exchanged the usual two sentences with Mrs. Devlin behind the counter, and accepted the usual small handful of correspondence — a gas bill, a circular from the parish council, a postcard from his sister — plus, this once, a single creamy envelope addressed in a hand he did not recognise.^[1]

hall cupboard; in later years, when the box was opened for the inquest, the envelope was the only item in it whose handwriting could not be matched to any known correspondent.

The envelope bore no stamp and no return address. It had been hand-delivered, presumably, though by whom Mrs. Devlin could not say — she had found it on the floor inside the door that morning, with the morning's pile of letters fanned around it as if it had been there first and the others had arrived to keep it company.^[2] He took the letter home, set it on the kitchen table beside the teapot, and looked at it for a long time before opening it.

the subject of considerable scrutiny. She maintained, against all reasonable pressure, that the envelope had been *under* the others when

¹Halloran kept all his correspondence in a wooden file box in the

²Mrs. Devlin's testimony at the inquest was, as one might expect,